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Big picture

Fifty-two years ago, women's cricket took shape through the one-day format. Unlike the men's game, where Test cricket occupies the peak of the cricketing Maslow's pyramid, ODIs are the zenith for the women. "We don't have anything close to a World Test Championship," Sthalekar exclaims. International red-ball cricket is restricted to four teams — Australia, England, India, and South Africa — with only the first two playing the format regularly, courtesy of the Ashes.

"Unless a higher aspiration presents itself, ODIs will be the peak," she adds.

While trends will come and go and the T20 format will continue to push its influence on others in the women's game, ODIs are the lifeline because of everything they bring along. Funding and stability of fixtures under the

Future Tours Programme are cushions that teams outside the top tier — men or women — desperately need. This, however, doesn't erase the reality that the financial capabilities of boards still dictate how competitive teams can be, and that conversation isn't happening on the most basic of levels.

Sthalekar urges patience and persistence in investment across the board. "T20s may be the driving vehicle, but why not add ODI fixtures when on bilateral tours? ICC is figuring out plans for that second tier. It's a hard issue because not all the boards can afford to create optimum opportunities. There's only so much money that they have to split up to go to the men's, the women's, grassroots, and so forth. That said, it is important, even at a state level, to keep exposing those players to the longer format, because it will allow players to understand how to build an innings, how to bowl in a spell, how to bowl in partnerships, how to set up a batter, not just hope the batter

Ultimate champion: Australian players celebrate their title win in the 2022 edition. They have won the title seven times. GETTY IMAGES

mishits it and you've got the fielders in the right position."

The 2029 edition of the Women's ODI World Cup is set to feature 10 teams. The competitive nature of the qualifiers over the last few years, across both white-ball formats, means exciting things for the ecosystem. Increasing viewership and following also means the vertical is now being treated as a business, which brings with it its own positives.

"There is an incentive to evolve. The approach of 'safety first, results later' doesn't fly with the generations coming into the game now. Those governing the game are viewing it as a business. It's no longer about 10-year or 15-year plans. Vision for the sport needs to evolve every few years, and the ecosystem has woken up to that reality," Raman says.